

CLIMATE CHANGE

INDIA'S WORRIES

WATER RESOURCES Decrease in Himalayan snow cover to affect the Brahmaputra, the Ganga and the Indus. Glacial melt will impact long-term lean season flow and generation of hydropower, causing decline in overall water availability.

AGRICULTURE AND FOOD Even a 1°C rise in surface temperatures will see the nation's wheat production drop by 4-5 million tonne. Small changes in temperature and rainfall to impact quality of fruits, vegetables, medicinal plants and rice.

HEALTH Changes in the climate may see a surge and spread of mosquito-related diseases, including malaria, into newer areas. Also, increase in temperature and humidity can raise the number of months during which mosquitoes are active.

FORESTS A majority of forest areas are likely to experience a shift in their types that will result in changes to forest produce, which in turn will impact livelihoods. Tropical forests may thin out into scrub jungle in many parts of the country.

EXTREME WEATHER Floods like the one that overwhelmed Mumbai and violent cyclones will become more frequent. Rising sea levels will see cities and towns in coastal areas inundated leading to large-scale migration.



many places. The melting of the Himalayan glaciers could prove catastrophic for those living downstream. Worse, rising sea levels would inundate many of our coastal cities forcing costly migrations. And extreme weather conditions like the Mumbai downpour are expected to happen more frequently resulting in loss of life and property.

So, is there much more that the country should be doing both domestically and internationally for climate change?

Don't let it end up as a wish list

The answer is both yes and no. While the national action plan unveiled is comprehensive and proactive in its approach, there is every danger that much of it would remain on paper unless the various ministries tasked to implement it act on it swiftly. As R.K. Pachauri, chairman of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) and a

MISSION NOT IMPOSSIBLE

As part of the national action plan, the Government has listed eight



SOLAR MISSION:

To promote the use of solar energy through solar photovoltaic and thermal systems for power generation. To also integrate other renewable energy technologies like biomass and wind.



ENERGY EFFICIENCY:

To mitigate GHG through sector-specific and cross-cutting technology and fuel switch options. To use more LNG and biomass fuels besides seeking tech transfer.



SUSTAINABLE HABITAT:

To promote energy efficiency in the residential and commercial sectors through LPG use. To better manage municipal solid waste and urban public transport.

member of the Prime Minister's Council on Climate Change put it: "The key is that the various concerned ministries do their homework well and come out with policies that can be translated into action. Otherwise the plan would remain a statement of intent."

Many of the non-governmental members of the Prime Minister's Council (including this author) emphasised working on targets and timetables to execute the plan. That's because climate change plans the world over have a poor track record where execution is concerned. Most developed countries, that had made a commitment under the 1997 Kyoto Protocol to reduce their carbon emissions by an average of 5 per cent compared to year 1990, have not met their targets. The US, the world's biggest GHG emitter, pulled out completely from the Protocol stating that unless developing countries like China and India also commit to some mandatory emission cuts, it would not rejoin.

Since the Protocol runs its course by 2012, international